Colegio International de Caracas

STUDY GUIDE

SAMUN 2026



EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

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Letters From the Chair

Distinguished Delegates,

It is our absolute pleasure to welcome you to this session of the committee.

When you choose to step into a Model United Nations chamber, you are making a conscious decision to engage with the world beyond your own immediate experience. The issues we gather to discuss are not abstract academic puzzles; they are real, pressing global challenges that affect millions of lives every single day. Navigating these problems requires a rare combination of qualities: the courage to stand up for principled positions, the intellectual rigour to analyze complex legal and political frameworks, and the humility to search for pragmatic compromise when opinions diverge.

Model United Nations is, at its core, a laboratory for leadership. It is a unique space designed to test your critical thinking, polish your public speaking, and sharpen your ability to negotiate under pressure. Over the course of our sessions, you will be asked to step into shoes that may feel unfamiliar, defend perspectives you might not personally hold, and collaborate with peers who bring vastly different viewpoints to the table. These moments of friction and negotiation are where true diplomacy happens.

Whether this conference marks your very first time taking the floor or you are a seasoned delegate returning to refine your craft, we encourage you to approach every unmoderated caucus, draft amendment, and speech with genuine curiosity and ambition. Come to the room well-prepared. Speak with clarity and conviction, back your arguments with concrete evidence, but above all, remain open to listening. The strongest resolutions are never written by a single voice in isolation—they are built through coalition, patience, and mutual respect.

The quality of our committee's work over the coming days will depend entirely on what you choose to bring into the room. We expect a high standard of respect, sharp argument, and active participation from every delegation present. Push past your comfort zone, ask difficult questions, and take full advantage of this forum to grow as a thinker and a leader.

We are incredibly excited to work alongside you and look forward to witnessing a debate that is intense, thoughtful, and deeply productive.

Warm regards,

Giovanna Renzella - Chair

Valentina Benavides—Co-Chair

Eliangel Andrade - Secretary

Matrix

Christian Ehler	**EPP** (European People's Party)	**Germany**
Tomas Tobé	**EPP** (European People's Party)	**Sweden**
Vangelis Meimarakis	**EPP** (European People's Party)	**Greece**
Karlo Ressler	**EPP** (European People's Party)	**Croatia**
Reinhold Lopatka	**EPP** (European People's Party)	**Austria**
Iratxe García Pérez	**S&D** (Socialists and Democrats)	**Spain**
Marta Temido	**S&D** (Socialists and Democrats)	**Portugal**
Christel Schaldemose	**S&D** (Socialists and Democrats)	**Denmark**
Eero Heinäluoma	**S&D** (Socialists and Democrats)	**Finland**
Jordan Bardella	**PfE** (Patriots for Europe)	**France**
René Aust	**ESN** (Europe of Sovereign Nations)	**Germany**
Sebastiaan Stöteler	**PfE** (Patriots for Europe)	**Netherlands**

Carlo Fidanza	**ECR** (European Conservatives and Reformists)	**Italy**
Adam Bielan	**ECR** (European Conservatives and Reformists)	**Poland**
Sophie Wilmès	**Renew** (Renew Europe)	**Belgium**
Petras Auštrevičius	**Renew** (Renew Europe)	**Lithuania**
Grace O'Sullivan	**Greens/EFA (**The Greens**)**	**Ireland**
Vladimir Prebilič	**Greens/EFA (**The Greens**)**	**Slovenia**
Kateřina Konečná	**The Left**	**Czech Republic**
Geadis Gead	**NI**	**Cyprus**

Introduction to the committee

The European Parliament is one of the main institutions of the European Union (EU) and serves as the democratic representative body for the citizens of its member states. The European Union is a political and economic organization made up of European countries that cooperate on issues such as trade, human rights, security, the environment, migration, and economic development. Within this system, the European Parliament represents the interests and opinions of European citizens. It is the only European Union institution whose members are directly elected by voters. Members of the European Parliament, commonly called MEPs, are elected every five years through elections held across the EU. Currently, the Parliament consists of 720 MEPs, with the number of representatives from each country generally based on its population. However, the system of "degressive proportionality" ensures that smaller countries are still fairly represented and that no country has fewer than six or more than ninety-six members .The European Parliament developed gradually as European countries began working together after World War II. Its earliest predecessor was the Common Assembly of the European Coal and Steel Community, created in the 1950s to encourage cooperation between European countries and prevent future conflict. At first, the assembly had limited authority and mainly provided advice and supervision. In 1962, it officially adopted the name "European Parliament." A major change occurred in 1979, when European citizens were first allowed to directly elect their representatives. Before that, members were chosen from national parliaments. Over time, the Parliament gained more influence over European laws, the EU budget, international agreements, and the supervision of other EU institutions. This development reflects the broader growth of democracy and cooperation within the European Union. The European Parliament has three principal responsibilities: legislative, supervisory, and budgetary. Its legislative role involves working with the Council of the European Union to discuss, change, and approve laws. Most European Union laws are proposed by the European Commission, which functions as the EU's executive body. The proposal is then considered by the Parliament and the Council. Both institutions must usually agree before a law can be adopted. These laws can affect many areas of daily life, including consumer protection, digital privacy, environmental standards, transportation, education, public health,

and workers' rights. Although the Parliament does not normally introduce laws independently in the same way that many national legislatures do, it can request that the European Commission prepare new legislation and can influence the content of proposed laws through debates and amendments.The Parliament also has an important supervisory function. It monitors the work of the European Commission and other EU institutions to make sure that they act according to European law and democratic principles. The Parliament elects the President of the European Commission and approves the members of the Commission as a group. It can question commissioners, conduct investigations, examine petitions from citizens, and debate important political issues. In serious circumstances, the Parliament can pass a motion of censure, which would require the European Commission to resign. These powers help prevent the EU's executive institutions from acting without accountability. In this way, the European Parliament plays a role similar to a national parliament when it investigates government actions and demands explanations from public officials.Another major responsibility of the European Parliament is its role in approving and supervising the EU budget. Together with the Council of the European Union, Parliament decides how European Union funds will be collected and spent. The budget supports programs involving regional development, scientific research, agriculture, education, humanitarian assistance, infrastructure, and climate action. Parliament also examines whether EU money has been used correctly and efficiently. This responsibility is especially important because it connects political decisions with financial resources. A policy cannot be successfully carried out unless the European Union provides money for it, so control of the budget gives the Parliament significant influence over the EU's priorities.The European Parliament is organized into political groups rather than traditional national parties. MEPs from different countries may belong to the same political group if they share similar political ideas. These groups can represent different viewpoints, including center-left, center-right, liberal, conservative, environmentalist, and other perspectives. MEPs also work in parliamentary committees that focus on specific subjects, such as foreign affairs, international trade, the environment, civil liberties, economic matters, or development. Committees study proposals in detail before they are debated and voted on by the entire Parliament. The Parliament holds formal meetings in Strasbourg, France, while many committee meetings and additional sessions take place in Brussels, Belgium. Its administrative offices are located mainly in Luxembourg.

Rules to the committee

General Rules

1. .Scope: The Committee Chair will be the final authority on what procedure to follow if a situation arises that has not been addressed by the Rules of Procedure. At the discretion of the Chair or Secretariat, these rules can be modified to better facilitate healthy debate, and any adjustment of the rules will be declared clearly to the entirety of the committee and will take precedence over any rules written in this document.

2. Nature of Representation: Delegates shall represent Members of the European Parliament (MEPs). Delegates must defend the political position of their assigned parliamentary group, such as the European People's Party, the Progressive Alliance of Socialists and Democrats, Renew Europe, the Greens/European Free Alliance, the European Conservatives and Reformists, or The Left. Delegates may consider national interests, but they shall primarily act according to their political group's ideology and policy priorities.

3. Language: English will be the official language used in MUN at CIC, in all documents and debates the English must be used.

4. General Power of the Committee Staff: The Chair has total control of the procedure of the meeting and any motion, the Chair is responsible to direct the flow of debate, grant the right to speak, ask questions, announce decisions, rule on points of order, and enforce adherence to these rules.

5. Quorum: It's the minimum quantity of delegates that are needed to start the conference.

6. Courtesy and Delegate Conduct: Every delegate must be respectful and courteous with conference members. If someone is being unrespectful, the Chairs must be contacted to take the appropriate action. CICMUN will have zero tolerance for slandering, disparaging, or any other respectful act.

7. Absence: If a delegate doesn’t appear during the conference, they won’t be receiving the certifications and awards. Just in case he or she sends a note to the chair justifying the absence

Topic 1: Immigration crisis in the European Union.

1. Topic Introduction

The challenge facing the European Union regarding migration and asylum is not merely an operational logistics issue; it is a fundamental debate over how a supranational bloc can balance international humanitarian obligations with national security, border control, and proportional burden-sharing among its Member States. The core dilemma within the European Union centers on the long-standing tension between supranational cooperation and Member State sovereignty. Under earlier legislative framework models, such as the Dublin III Regulation, the responsibility for evaluating asylum claims was placed on the first EU Member State of entry. This design placed a disproportionate administrative, logistical, and financial strain on frontline coastal nations—primarily Greece, Italy, Spain, and Cyprus—while interior and landlocked Member States remained relatively insulated. The resulting systemic backlog led to recurring humanitarian emergencies in border facilities, internal political friction over mandatory relocation quotas, and temporary border checks within the Schengen Area.

To navigate this issue effectively, delegates must establish precise legal terminology, distinguishing between terms that carry distinct legal definitions, rights, and obligations under international law. Strictly defined by the 1951 UN Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol, a refugee is an individual who, owing to a well-founded fear of being persecuted for reasons of race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group, or political opinion, is outside the country of their nationality and is unable or unwilling to avail themselves of the protection of that country. The 1951 Convention explicitly prohibits *non-refoulement*, which is the practice of returning refugees or asylum seekers to countries where their life or freedom would be threatened. In contrast, according to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), an asylum seeker is an individual who has crossed an international border seeking sanctuary and international protection, but whose claim to refugee status has not yet been formally processed or determined by the host state. While not every asylum seeker is ultimately granted refugee status, all asylum seekers are entitled to due process and fundamental human rights protections while their claims are evaluated. Furthermore, while there is no universally binding international legal definition for a migrant, the United Nations widely understands

the term to cover individuals who move across international borders primarily for economic, educational, or personal reasons rather than an immediate fear of persecution or violence, meaning they generally operate under the national immigration laws of the host state. Finally, irregular migration refers specifically to the movement of individuals crossing borders outside the established legal, regulatory, or administrative frameworks of destination or transit countries.

In this committee session, delegates in the European Parliament must focus their research and legislative solutions on four key components: the standardization of border procedures, solidarity and burden-sharing, human rights and legal safeguards, and the external dimension of migration alongside return policies. First, delegates must address how to establish fair, swift, and uniform border screening, biometric identification, and asylum processing standards across all EU external entry points. Second, the committee must focus on developing acceptable operational, administrative, and financial support mechanisms between frontline states and interior states to ensure equitable responsibility distribution. Third, delegates must guarantee that border enforcement operations, fast-track processing zones, and third-country partnerships fully respect international refugee law, the principle of *non-refoulement*, and the Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union. Fourth, the committee must evaluate bilateral agreements with transit countries outside the EU to manage migration routes and establish unified procedures for returning individuals whose protection claims are rejected. Delegates are expected to negotiate across transnational Political Groups—such as the European People's Party (EPP), Socialists and Democrats (S&D), Renew Europe, Greens/EFA, European Conservatives and Reformists (ECR), Patriots for Europe (PfE), and The Left—rather than as strict national representatives. By working across these ideological families, delegates will draft comprehensive legislative resolutions that address border security, uphold humanitarian standards, and foster European integration.

2. History of the Topic

The structural origins of the European Union’s current migration framework trace back to the creation of the Schengen Area in 1985 (enacted in 1995), which abolished internal border controls between participating European states. To balance free internal movement with regional security, EU Member States recognized the need for a unified external border policy and a standardized asylum evaluation system. This led to the establishment of the Dublin Convention in 1990, which was later codified into the Dublin II and Dublin III

Regulations in 2003 and 2013, respectively. The foundational principle of the Dublin framework dictated that the primary responsibility for processing an asylum seeker's claim lies with the first EU Member State of entry. While designed to prevent multiple applications across different Member States, the regulation inherently created a structural geographic imbalance. Frontline coastal nations in Southern Europe became legally and operationally responsible for the vast majority of incoming asylum seekers, while landlocked and interior states were largely insulated from immediate administrative obligations.

The operational viability of the Dublin III Regulation collapsed during the 2015–2016 European Migration Crisis, when over 1.3 million people arrived on European shores seeking asylum within a single year. Driven by escalating civil wars in Syria, ongoing instability in Afghanistan and Iraq, and socio-economic displacement across North Africa, the primary transit routes overwhelmed reception infrastructure in frontline states. In response, several transit and destination countries suspended key elements of the Schengen agreement, reinstating temporary internal border checks. Attempts by the European Commission to institute emergency mandatory relocation quotas for asylum seekers met intense political resistance, particularly from Central and Eastern European nations, creating unprecedented political fragmentation within the bloc.

To manage the crisis, the European Union pursued external diplomatic and financial partnerships with non-EU transit countries. The 2016 EU-Turkey Statement represented an agreement where Turkey committed to securing its borders and accepting the return of irregular migrants arriving in Greece, in exchange for European financial aid and refugee resettlement commitments. Additionally, EU cooperation with Libyan authorities focused on financial and technical support to intercept migrant vessels in the Central Mediterranean. While these external agreements led to reductions in sea arrivals, they drew criticism from international human rights bodies regarding safety concerns, detention conditions, and compliance with international law.

The development and management of the EU migration issue involve a complex array of supranational, national, and international actors. Within the EU, the European Parliament serves as a co-legislator alongside the Council of the EU under the Ordinary Legislative Procedure, with its Committee on Civil Liberties, Justice and Home Affairs (LIBE) overseeing asylum legislation and human rights compliance. Executive agencies including the European Border and Coast Guard Agency (Frontex) manage external border monitoring

and return operations, while the European Union Agency for Asylum (EUAA) provides operational support to national asylum systems. Internationally, United Nations bodies—such as the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and the International Organization for Migration (IOM)—alongside non-governmental organizations, monitor international protection standards, operate humanitarian interventions, and conduct search-and-rescue operations. Key UN frameworks guiding these efforts include the foundational 1951 Refugee Convention and the 2018 Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration.

3. Discussion of the Topic

The primary controversies within European migration governance center on balancing national sovereignty, regional security, and binding international human rights obligations. Although the European Parliament adopted the New Pact on Migration and Asylum (passed in 2024 and reaching full implementation in 2026), core political and legal disagreements persist regarding its implementation and long-term viability. The most contentious debate involves mandatory solidarity mechanisms versus national sovereignty. Frontline Member States continue to argue for mandatory relocation mechanisms to alleviate administrative pressures. Conversely, several interior states reject mandatory relocation quotas, asserting that national governments must maintain complete authority over entry into their territories. The compromise established under the New Pact—allowing Member States to choose between accepting relocated asylum seekers, making financial contributions per rejected applicant, or providing operational support—remains a subject of intense political debate.

A second major issue involves the legality, effectiveness, and humanitarian implications of accelerated border screening and fast-track processing procedures. Under recent reforms, mandatory health, security, and biometric checks are conducted at external borders within an accelerated timeframe. Applicants originating from countries with low statistical asylum approval rates are placed into fast-track border procedures. While proponents contend these measures prevent administrative backlogs and streamline returns, civil society groups and legal scholars argue that accelerated evaluations undermine due process, restrict access to qualified legal counsel, and lead to systematic border detention.

The policy of border externalization—delegating border management, interception, and asylum processing duties to non-EU third countries—presents significant legal and ethical controversy. Supporter states advocate for partnerships with non-EU transit nations as

an effective means to prevent dangerous sea crossings and dismantle human smuggling operations. However, international human rights organizations and UN rapporteurs argue that outsourcing border control to third-party nations with weaker human rights protections risks bypassing the principle of *non-refoulement* and violating international law. Furthermore, the continued reintroduction of temporary internal border controls by individual Member States raises questions regarding compliance with Schengen governance and threatens the principle of free internal movement within the Union.

Political objectives within the European Parliament mirror these regional and ideological divides. Frontline states prioritize mandatory burden-sharing, operational assistance from Frontex, and direct EU funding for processing infrastructure. Interior states prioritize restricting secondary movements and ensuring strict enforcement of external screening protocols. Within the European Parliament, progressive political groups emphasize expanding legal pathways, funding search-and-rescue operations, and protecting human rights. In contrast, conservative and right-leaning political families focus on border security, expanding the mandate of Frontex, swift deportation of rejected applicants, and expanding externalthird-country agreements.

Representatives position

Christian Ehler	Supports strict external border management and accelerated asylum screening protocols to curb irregular arrivals and secondary

	movements within the EU. His position is driven by the interest of interior Member States to prevent uncoordinated secondary migration, which he justifies as essential for maintaining Schengen free movement and public order. To advance this agenda, he advocates for enforcing the New Pact on Migration and Asylum screening framework and securing EU-wide border controls.
Tomas Tobé	Advocates for rigorous external border screening, fast-tracked return procedures for ineligible applicants, and tying foreign development aid to third-country migration cooperation. His stance is justified by the need to manage overall European migratory flows efficiently while deterring illegal smuggling operations. He actively pushes for expanding Frontex operational capacities, funding border infrastructure, and establishing binding third-country return agreements.
Vangelis Meimarakis	prioritizes robust external border protection, fast-tracked processing, and immediate EU operational support for frontline states. As an MEP representing a frontline Mediterranean entry point facing continuous maritime arrivals, his position is justified by the heavy administrative burden placed on coastal border nations. He focuses on securing direct deployments from Frontex and financial relief to bolster Greece's border infrastructure.

Karlo Ressler	focuses on strict border surveillance, rapid identity checks, and preventing unrecorded land crossings along key transit routes. Representing a country along the Western Balkans route, his stance is justified by the necessity of securing EU land borders against irregular transit. He actively supports deploying enhanced border technology, strengthening Frontex presence, and expediting asylum screenings at external entry points
Reinhold Lopatka	champions stringent border screening protocols, efficient deportations, and conditional foreign aid to curb incoming migration. His platform is justified by Austria's position as a landlocked destination country seeking to alleviate secondary domestic pressures. He advocates for enforcing border screening measures, expanding safe third-country agreements, and accelerating returns of rejected applicants.
Iratxe García Pérez	advocates strongly for mandatory European burden-sharing, legal migration pathways, and guaranteed humanitarian protections. Representing a major Southern border nation receiving maritime arrivals, her position is justified by the principle of European solidarity to prevent frontline states from bearing isolated administrative weight. She actively pursues mandatory EU relocation allocations, increased financial

	support for frontline reception, and active search-and-rescue operations.
Marta Temido	prioritizes humane reception standards, structural integration policies, and equitable solidarity mechanisms across all Member States. Her stance is justified by the progressive commitment to international refugee conventions, fundamental human rights, and shared responsibility. She focuses on establishing legal labor migration channels, funding dignified reception facilities, and guaranteeing legal safeguards during asylum reviews.
Christel Schaldemose	represents a pragmatist social-democratic position balancing controlled border management with domestic social welfare protection. This approach is justified by national domestic priorities that favor firm migration management to preserve internal public resources and social cohesion. She supports standardized asylum screening alongside strict border controls while maintaining compliance with baseline EU legal standards.
Eero Heinäluoma	emphasizes strict compliance with the rule of law, due process for asylum seekers, and protecting vulnerable populations. His position is justified by the moral and legal obligation to uphold the EU Charter of Fundamental Rights and international refugee law. He pursues policies that

	guarantee individual access to legal counsel, prevent forced returns violating *non-refoulement*, and establish mandatory relocation contributions.
Jordan Bardella	demands the complete restoration of national border sovereignty, the rejection of mandatory EU relocation quotas, and strict restriction of irregular immigration flows. His stance is justified by a right-wing sovereigntist ideology prioritizing national identity, state security, and political independence over supranational mandates. He advocates for physical border controls, the externalization of asylum processing, and immediate deportation procedures.
René Aust	rejects centralized EU asylum frameworks in favor of full national border controls, immediate turnbacks, and aggressive remigration policies. His position is justified by hard-right principles asserting that immigration control must remain strictly under national capital jurisdiction to protect sovereign interests. He actively opposes mandatory solidarity mechanisms, pursuing instead national border closures and accelerated expulsion processes.
Sebastiaan Stöteler	focuses on enforcing strict national border controls, opting out of mandatory distribution schemes, and capping overall immigration numbers. His stance is justified by sovereign political priorities aimed at

	curbing secondary domestic pressures and preserving national autonomy. He actively supports halting mandatory EU distribution mechanisms, establishing offshore processing centers, and enforcing immediate deportations.
Carlo Fidanza	advocates for offshore third-country asylum processing, naval blockade cooperation, and firm border enforcement. Representing a heavily exposed Mediterranean state, his hard-right approach is justified by national security interests and the drive to deter maritime arrivals before reaching Italian territory. He pursues policies modeled on external bilateral agreements—such as the Italy-Albania model—to process claims outside the EU while rejecting mandatory domestic relocation schemes.
Adam Bielan	defends national border sovereignty against EU supranational mandates and strictly rejects any financial penalties for opting out of relocation quotas. His position is justified by the Eastern European defense imperative that views border security as a matter of state defense rather than centralized European management. He actively pursues policies that block mandatory relocation mechanisms, externalize asylum procedures, and preserve national veto rights over migration decisions
Sophie Wilmès	supports a pragmatic balance between

	external border security, efficient administrative processing, and targeted legal migration channels. Her centrist stance is justified by the need to maintain the single market and protect Schengen free movement while meeting European economic labor shortages. She pursues policies focused on digitalized asylum screening, flexible solidarity mechanisms, and harmonized European processing standards.
Petras Auštrevičius	prioritizes security along the EU's Eastern land border, focusing on defense against hybrid threats and irregular crossings while upholding the rule of law. His approach is justified by Lithuania's immediate proximity to external geopolitical tensions requiring rigorous state security. He advocates for streamlined border screening protocols, enhanced border infrastructure funding, and balanced labor migration frameworks.
Grace O'Sullivan	champions humanitarian protection, active state-funded search-and-rescue operations, and legal passage corridors. Her platform is justified by an ecologist and progressive commitment to human rights, international refugee law, and the prohibition of forced returns. She actively opposes border detention facilities, externalization deals with non-EU states, and militarized border enforcement.

Vladimir Prebilič	focuses on ensuring humane reception conditions, access to legal counsel, and the recognition of climate-induced displacement. His position is justified by a human-rights-centered framework that prioritizes individual protections over restrictive border measures. He pursues policies advocating for safe and legal migration routes, expanding refugee resettlement, and abolishing fast-track border detentions.
Kateřina Konečná	opposes militarized border policies and commercialized security operations, advocating instead for root-cause foreign aid and humanitarian protections. Her stance is justified by anti-militarist and left-wing principles that critique coercive externalization policies as violations of fundamental human rights. She pursues policies to dismantle closed border detention centers, expand humanitarian visas, and eliminate mandatory fast-track border processing.
Geadis Gead	focuses strictly on the disproportionate demographic impact of migration on Cyprus, demanding immediate relocation of arrivals to other EU states and strict island border enforcement. As a Non-Inscribed member, his isolated focus is justified by localized national pressures on a frontline island nation operating outside transnational party discipline. He actively pursues ad-hoc

	voting strategies to demand direct national financial aid, emergency relocation relief, and localized border enforcement exceptions.

Relevant UN Treaties, Resolutions and reports

Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees (1951)

- Date Written: July 28, 1951
- The foundational legal treaty establishing international refugee law. It provides the universally accepted definition of a refugee, outlines the legal status and rights of individuals fleeing persecution, and enshrines the fundamental principle of *non-refoulement*—prohibiting states from returning individuals to territories where they face life-threatening danger or persecution.
- Full Document: **UNOHCHRTreaty Text**

Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees (1967)

- Date Written: January 31, 1967
- : An essential amendment to the 1951 Convention that removed its original temporal and geographic limitations (which had limited protection primarily to post-WWII European refugees), applying refugee protections universally across all regions and timeframes.
- Full Document: **UNHCRLegal Document Library**

Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration (A/RES/73/195)

- Date Written: Adopted December 19, 2018

- The first intergovernmental, non-binding agreement negotiated under UN auspices covering all dimensions of international migration. It outlines 23 objectives to strengthen international cooperation, mitigate the drivers of irregular migration, protect migrant human rights, and improve safe transit and integration mechanisms.
- Full Document**:** UNDigitalLibrary - ResolutionA/RES/73/195

Global Compact on Refugees (A/73/12 Part II)

- Date Written: Adopted December 17, 2018
- A non-binding framework endorsed by the UN General Assembly to improve international response mechanisms to large-scale refugee movements. It aims to ease pressure on host countries, enhance refugee self-reliance, expand third-country solutions (such as resettlement), and support conditions in countries of origin for safe return.
  Full Document
- **:** UNHCRGlobalCompactFramework

UN General Assembly Resolution on the Protection of Migrants (A/RES/80/218)

- Date Written: Adopted December 18, 2025
- A recent General Assembly resolution focusing on safeguarding the human rights and fundamental freedoms of all migrants, regardless of their legal status. It calls upon Member States to combat xenophobia, address humanitarian vulnerabilities during international border crossings, and ensure compliance with international law during border enforcement and detention procedures.
- Full Document**:** UNDigitalLibrary-ResolutionA/RES/80/218

UN Secretary-General Report: Human Rights of Migrants (A/80/302)

- Date Written: Published August 4, 2025
- An authoritative UN report providing an up-to-date assessment of human rights challenges faced by migrants globally. It specifically evaluates regional cooperation arrangements, externalized border management practices, search and rescue operations in maritime routes, and compliance with human rights standards at transit borders.
- Full Document: UN Official Document System / ReliefWeb Entry

Past Actions

The Dublin III Regulation (2013)

The Dublin III Regulation (Regulation No 604/2013) was enacted by the European Parliament and the Council of the European Union across EU Member States to establish a standardized legal framework for determining which nation holds primary responsibility for examining an asylum application. Under its core protocol, responsibility was assigned to the first EU country of entry.

This attempt failed because it created a severe geographical imbalance by shifting the overwhelming administrative, financial, and logistical burden onto frontline Southern European states—such as Greece, Italy, and Spain—while interior and landlocked nations remained largely insulated from processing obligations. The system completely stalled during the 2015 migration surge when frontline states were overwhelmed by over 1.3 million arrivals, leading to secondary movements across the Schengen zone, widespread non-compliance, and the temporary reintroduction of internal border controls. To improve future frameworks, responsibility mechanisms must replace strict first-country rules with mandatory, flexible solidarity mechanisms that distribute processing, financial, and logistical support across all Member States.

Emergency Relocation Schemes (2015)

In response to the unprecedented migration surge, the European Commission, supported by the European Parliament and Council, introduced temporary emergency relocation decisions to forcibly redistribute 160,000 asylum seekers from overburdened frontline states (Greece and Italy) across other EU Member States using mandatory quota allocations.

This attempt failed due to intense political polarization, ideological opposition, and outright refusal by several Central and Eastern European Member States—most notably the Visegrád Group (Poland, Hungary, the Czech Republic, and Slovakia)—to accept mandated quotas. Enforcement mechanisms were virtually nonexistent, resulting in only a small fraction of the targeted relocations actually being fulfilled. Future efforts must abandon rigid,

non-negotiable relocation quotas in favor of adaptable solidarity models that allow states to choose between accepting transfers, funding border management and reception infrastructure, or providing direct operational assistance.

The EU-Turkey Statement (2016)

Negotiated directly between the European Council and the Government of Turkey in Brussels, this bilateral agreement aimed to break the business model of human smugglers operating across the Aegean Sea toward Greece. Under the agreement, Turkey agreed to secure its maritime borders and accept the return of all irregular migrants arriving on Greek islands from its territory, while the EU committed €6 billion in humanitarian aid, visa-liberalization talks, and a "one-for-one" Syrian refugee resettlement scheme.

While the agreement drastically reduced sea arrivals in the short term, it ultimately faltered as a long-term solution due to heavy reliance on a single non-EU partner, mounting legal challenges, and deteriorating diplomatic relations. Furthermore, processing backlogs on Greek islands led to severe overcrowding in containment camps, while international oversight bodies criticized the arrangement over human rights standards and non-refoulement risks. Future bilateral partnerships must integrate strict, independent human rights monitoring frameworks and diversify regional diplomatic cooperation rather than over-relying on single transit nations.

EU-Libya Cooperation Framework (2017–Present)

Initiated through bilateral arrangements led by Italy and institutionalized via the European Commission and the EU Trust Fund for Africa, this operational initiative provided funding, naval vessels, radar technology, and training to the Libyan Coast Guard. The target area centered on the Central Mediterranean transit route off the coast of North Africa to intercept migrant vessels before they reached international or European waters.

This policy failed from a humanitarian and legal perspective because it outsourced border enforcement to a politically volatile nation lacking a unified central government or robust rule of law. Intercepted migrants were routinely returned to informal Libyan detention centers, facing documented human rights abuses, extortions, and unsafe conditions, drawing sharp condemnation from UN agencies including the UNHCR and UNHRC. Next time, external interception assistance must be strictly conditional upon verified adherence to

international human rights laws, clear oversight of reception facilities, and dedicated search-and-rescue protocols.

The New Pact on Migration and Asylum (2024–2026)

Adopted by the European Parliament and the Council of the European Union, the New Pact represents a comprehensive legislative overhaul designed to modernize European asylum and border infrastructure. Implemented across external EU borders, it introduces fast-track mandatory screening within seven days, biometric tracking via the Eurodac database, and a flexible "mandatory solidarity" framework that allows Member States to choose between relocation transfers, financial contributions (€20,000 per applicant), or operational deployments.

Despite being the most significant structural reform to date, early implementation stages face friction due to operational vulnerabilities along external borders—such as sudden surge events in the Spanish enclave of Ceuta—and ongoing political resistance from Member States refusing financial contribution mandates. To ensure its long-term viability, future administrative steps must focus on establishing rapid crisis-response mechanisms, ensuring human rights compliance during fast-track border screenings, and creating clear legal pathways for migration to reduce pressure on asylum channels.

Guiding questions

What specific structural, legal, and humanitarian deficiencies in the European Union’s current asylum framework (such as the Dublin Regulation) have prevented an effective and equitable response to influxes of migrants and refugees?

Which key actors—including EU institutions (e.g., Frontex, European Commission), national governments of frontline vs. interior member states, and international bodies (e.g., UNHCR)—bear responsibility for managing asylum processing and border security?

What concrete policy measures and structural reforms (such as mandatory burden-sharing quotas or modernized border processing protocols) can the European Union implement to balance human rights compliance with national security priorities?

How can the financial and logistical costs of processing, hosting, and integrating migrants be allocated equitably among member states, and why is a centralized EU funding mechanism more sustainable than unilateral national expenditures?

What monitoring mechanisms and legal oversight frameworks are required to evaluate member state compliance with international human rights standards and measure the long-term socio-economic integration of recognized refugees?

What sequence of short-term emergency responses and long-term institutional reforms must be scheduled over the next decade to establish a resilient and adaptable EU migration and asylum policy?

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Further Reading

- **European Parliament Research Service (EPRS) Briefings:** Migration and Asylum" – Offers detailed legislative breakdowns of screening regulations, border procedures, and political group positions. https://www.europarl.europa.eu/thinktank/en/home[cite: 1]
- **Migration Policy Institute Europe (MPI Europe):** Independent policy studies analyzing the practical implementation challenges of European asylum reforms and burden-sharing mechanisms. https://www.migrationpolicy.org/programs/mpi-europe[cite: 1]
- **Centre for European Policy Studies (CEPS):** Policy papers exploring the balance between external border management, Schengen Area integrity, and national sovereignty. https://www.ceps.eu/topics/migration-and-asylum/[cite: 1]
- **European Council on Refugees and Exiles (ECRE):** Reports and legal analysis on human rights compliance, fundamental rights at EU external borders, and safe-third-country policies. https://ecre.org/publications/[cite: 1]

- **UNHCR Operational Data Portal (Mediterranean Situation):** Real-time data, statistical trends, and demographic breakdowns of sea and land arrivals across European transit routes.
  https://data.unhcr.org/en/situations/mediterranean[cite: 1]

Topic 2: Military Dependence on the United States.

Topic Introduction

One of the major challenges facing European security today is its military dependence on the United States. NATO continues to be the foundation of collective defence and the transatlantic partnership with Washington remains essential to Europe's defence, however many European Union Member States are heavily dependent on US military capacities, intelligence, logistics, nuclear deterrence, command structures and defence equipment. This

reliance has brought Europe security for decades, but it also constrains the European Union in its ability to act independently in foreign policy, defence planning and crisis response.

The issue has become increasingly urgent following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, which exposed critical European gaps in areas such as surveillance, air-to-air refuelling, strategic airlift, long-range precision strike, and command and control. At the same time, uncertainty surrounding future US foreign-policy priorities has raised concerns that Europe may no longer be able to assume uninterrupted American military support. The European Parliament has therefore called for stronger European defence capabilities, coordinated defence spending, contingency planning, and a more credible "European pillar" within NATO, while preserving cooperation with the United States. For the European Parliament, the challenge is not to end Europe's alliance with the United States but to ensure that European security no longer depends excessively on American military support. Achieving this balance will require sustained investment in European defence industries, closer cooperation among Member States, stronger EU-NATO coordination, and the development of capabilities that allow Europe to respond effectively to crises on its own. This research paper analyses why Europe has become militarily dependent on the United States, assesses the consequences of that dependence for European strategic autonomy, and explores practical policies that can make Europe more capable of defending itself while preserving a strong and reliable transatlantic partnership.

History of the Topic

Europe's military dependence on the United States is not a new phenomenon but rather the result of historical, political and security conditions that emerged in the wake of World War II and have continued to inform European defence policy to the present day. After the destruction of World War II, many European countries were economically weakened, politically unstable and militarily exhausted. At the same time, the Soviet Union was extending its influence throughout Eastern Europe, raising fears in Western European governments that Soviet aggression might extend further west. The United States became the main guarantor of Western Europe's security, determined to prevent another catastrophic European war and to contain Soviet expansion. This relationship was formalised through the creation of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) in 1949, an alliance built on the principle of collective defence. Under Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty, an armed attack against one NATO member is considered an attack against all members. For European states,

NATO provided a powerful security guarantee; for the United States, it created a framework through which it could organise the defence of Europe and limit Soviet influence.

During the Cold War, Europe's reliance on the United States increased dramatically. The United States stationed hundreds of thousands of troops in Europe, deployed nuclear weapons on the continent, supplied advanced military technology, and provided intelligence, command structures, logistics, and strategic planning. European governments largely accepted this arrangement because the benefits of American protection appeared to outweigh the costs. The United States' "security umbrella" allowed Western European countries to rebuild their economies, strengthen democratic institutions, and devote fewer resources to maintaining enormous standing armies. However, this arrangement also reduced the incentive for European states to develop fully independent military capabilities. Instead of building a unified European defence system, many countries focused on national forces and relied on Washington for the most advanced and strategically important capabilities. As a result, Europe became dependent not only on US troops and nuclear deterrence, but also on American intelligence, satellite communications, air refuelling, strategic transport, and high-end weapons systems.

Several long-term causes explain why this dependence developed and persisted. First, the destruction caused by the Second World War left European states unable to defend themselves effectively without external assistance. Second, the Soviet threat made collective defence under US leadership appear essential to Western Europe's survival. Third, NATO's structure gave European countries access to American military planning, nuclear deterrence, and command systems, which encouraged continued reliance on the alliance. Fourth, European defence industries remained fragmented: countries often developed weapons systems nationally rather than cooperating across borders, leading to duplication, higher costs, and limited interoperability. Fifth, after the Cold War, many European governments reduced defence spending, assuming that the United States would continue to guarantee European security. Finally, Europe developed strong forces in certain areas but continued to lack key strategic capabilities, including long-range precision strike, large-scale airlift, surveillance, reconnaissance, and advanced command-and-control systems. These gaps meant that even when European countries contributed troops to international operations, they often depended on the United States to transport, supply, protect, and coordinate their forces. The end of the Cold War in 1991 reduced the immediate danger of a large-scale conflict in Europe, but it did not eliminate Europe's dependence on the United States. In fact, the post-Cold War period created a new problem: European governments reduced military

budgets and force sizes during the so-called “peace dividend,” while the United States remained the dominant military power within NATO. During the 1990s and 2000s, European forces participated in operations in the Balkans, Afghanistan, Libya, Iraq, and Africa. These missions repeatedly revealed Europe’s inability to conduct major military operations independently. European states could often provide soldiers, funding, and political support, but they frequently relied on the United States for intelligence, precision-guided weapons, air-to-air refuelling, strategic airlift, satellite communications, and overall command. Therefore, although the number of US troops stationed permanently in Europe decreased after the Cold War, Europe’s operational dependence on American capabilities remained significant .The situation became far more urgent after Russia’s annexation of Crimea in 2014 and especially after Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. These events demonstrated that large-scale conventional war had returned to Europe and exposed serious weaknesses in European defence. Many European countries lacked sufficient ammunition stocks, air-defence systems, long-range weapons, logistics capacity, and industrial production capacity. The war also showed that Europe could not quickly replace certain US-provided capabilities, such as advanced intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance, strategic airlift, and satellite communications. The European Parliament has recognised that Russia’s aggression caused a dramatic deterioration in European security and requires the European Union to strengthen its defence capacity and support Ukraine more effectively. At the same time, uncertainty surrounding the future of United States foreign policy has made the issue more pressing. Europe can no longer assume that American military support will remain unlimited, automatic, or politically stable. The European Parliament has stated that the European Union must act urgently to ensure its own autonomous security, strengthen partnerships with like-minded countries, and significantly reduce its dependencies on non-EU countries. This does not mean that Europe should abandon NATO or end its partnership with the United States. Rather, it means that Europe must become capable of defending itself and contributing more equally to collective security. The European Parliament has supported initiatives such as the European Defence Fund, the European Defence Industry Programme, and Permanent Structured Cooperation (PESCO), all of which aim to improve European defence cooperation, increase industrial capacity, and reduce fragmentation among Member States. The main actors involved in this issue include the United States, NATO, the European Union, EU Member States, the European Parliament, Russia, and the European defence industry. The United States remains Europe’s most important military ally and provides essential capabilities, including nuclear deterrence, intelligence, logistics, and advanced equipment.

NATO remains the central framework for collective defence and military coordination between North America and Europe. The European Union has become increasingly active in defence policy through the Common Security and Defence Policy, PESCO, and defence-industrial programmes. EU Member States, however, still control most armed forces, defence budgets, and procurement decisions, which makes coordination difficult. The European Parliament plays an important role by promoting stronger European defence cooperation and calling for reduced external dependencies. Russia's actions, particularly its war against Ukraine, have intensified the urgency of the debate. Finally, European and American defence companies influence Europe's ability to produce weapons, ammunition, and advanced military technology. Although the United Nations does not directly control NATO or European defence policy, it remains relevant because European military capacity affects international peace and security. Article 51 of the UN Charter recognises the right of individual and collective self-defence, while UN peacekeeping and crisis-management efforts often depend on European troops, funding, and logistics. Over time, Europe's dependence on the United States has changed rather than disappeared: it was greatest during the Cold War, weakened in terms of US troop presence after 1991, but became more serious after Russia's invasion of Ukraine exposed Europe's military and industrial gaps. Today, Europe still relies heavily on US intelligence, nuclear deterrence, equipment, and supply chains, even as it increases defence spending and pursues greater strategic autonomy. The central challenge for the European Parliament is therefore to strengthen European defence capabilities and reduce excessive dependence on Washington without weakening NATO or the transatlantic partnership that has supported European security since 1949.

Discussion of the Topic

The main controversy is whether Europe can continue relying on the United States for security while still maintaining strategic autonomy. Supporters of the transatlantic alliance argue that US military power remains essential because Europe depends on American nuclear deterrence, intelligence, satellite communications, strategic airlift, and advanced weapons systems. Reducing this support too quickly could weaken NATO and leave Europe vulnerable, especially after Russia's invasion of Ukraine showed that large-scale war has returned to the continent. However, critics argue that dependence on the United States limits Europe's independence. If US political priorities change, Europe may struggle to respond to crises, defend its interests, or conduct military operations without American support. The European Parliament has warned that reliance on US defence and security support reduces

the EU's capacity to act independently. A further issue is the unequal burden within NATO. The United States has repeatedly called on European allies to spend more on defence, while European states differ in their threat perceptions, military budgets, and strategic priorities. Eastern and Northern European countries generally support stronger deterrence against Russia, while other Member States may prioritise different security concerns. These divisions make it difficult for the EU to create a unified defence policy. Europe's fragmented defence industry is another major problem. Member States often buy weapons nationally or from the United States instead of cooperating on joint European projects. This leads to higher costs, duplicated production, and shortages of ammunition and key equipment. The war in Ukraine has exposed these weaknesses, and the European Parliament has criticised decades of national procurement, underinvestment, and industrial fragmentation. The role of US defence companies is also controversial. American equipment can provide Europe with advanced capabilities quickly, but it may deepen Europe's reliance on US supply chains, spare parts, maintenance, and export approvals. Delegates must therefore consider whether Europe should prioritise immediate military effectiveness or long-term industrial independence. Nuclear deterrence is especially sensitive. Europe's security has long depended on the US nuclear umbrella, but this means that Europe's ultimate protection depends partly on decisions made in Washington. France and the United Kingdom possess nuclear weapons, but neither fully replaces the role of US nuclear deterrence within NATO. Existing responses have had mixed results. NATO has strengthened its eastern flank and improved readiness, while the EU has created initiatives such as PESCO, the European Defence Fund, and the European Defence Industry Programme. However, these measures have not yet eliminated Europe's capability gaps. Critics argue that EU defence projects are too slow and underfunded, while supporters see them as necessary steps toward a stronger and more autonomous Europe.The United Nations has limited direct influence over this issue. Although the UN Charter recognises collective self-defence, the Security Council often cannot act effectively because permanent members can use their veto. Russia's invasion of Ukraine showed this limitation clearly. Therefore, Europe cannot rely on the UN alone for protection and must maintain strong regional defence arrangements. Ultimately, the issue involves competing interests. The United States wants allies to share more of the defence burden, EU institutions seek greater European integration, Member States protect national sovereignty and industries, Russia benefits from European division, and defence companies have economic interests in increased military spending. Because military dependence affects sovereignty, alliance

loyalty, economics, and security, it remains one of the most difficult issues facing the European Parliament .

Representative positions

Christian Ehler	Prioritizes expanding EU research and industrial capacity (EDF) to reduce technological vulnerabilities while preserving transatlantic ties
Tomas Tobé	Urges European allies to scale up domestic defence spending, strengthening NATO's European pillar to balance reliance on American forces.
Vangelis Meimarakis	Advocates collective EU capacity development for regional threats while maintaining NATO as the primary security guarantor.
Karlo Ressler	Focuses on reinforcing Eastern Europe's military posture to relieve burden-sharing pressure on the US military.
Reinhold Lopatka	Supports localized defence manufacturing and procurement to secure supply chains without distancing Europe from Washington.
Iratxe García Pérez	It advocates “open strategic autonomy”, claiming that the EU must jointly fund defence in order for it to be able to act independently of US foreign policy shifts.

Marta Temido	Promotes sovereign supply chains and pooled European procurement to curb reliance on US defence contractors.
Christel Schaldemose	Encourages joint EU technology ventures and military coordination to enhance European self-reliance within NATO.
Eero Heinäluoma	Pushes for expanded European arms and ammunition production so the continent can secure its immediate borders independently
Jordan Bardella	Rejects EU-level defence integration, demanding national sovereignty and a strong domestic defence industry free from US dominance.
René Aust	Opposes supranational EU military structures and American strategic influence, advocating for strictly national defence forces.
Sebastiaan Stöteler	Denounces centralized EU defence federalism and expresses skepticism toward foreign security guarantees, favouring national defence.
Carlo Fidanza	Calls for modernizing national militaries inside NATO, urging higher defence budgets to diminish sole dependence on US protection.
Adam Bielan	Maintains an Atlanticist stance, insisting US military power is irreplaceable for Eastern European security and warning against EU strategic autonomy.

Sophie Wilmès	Pushes for a European Defence Union to turn Europe into an equal, self-standing partner alongside Washington.
Petras Auštrevičius	Demands swift European rearmament and higher budgets, arguing Europe must manage its own regional deterrence alongside NATO.
Grace O'Sullivan	Rejects both EU militarization and the American defence industry, calling for investment in diplomacy and climate security over arms.
Vladimir Prebilič	Views European defence self-sufficiency as a pragmatic requirement to protect Europe from political unpredictability in Washington.
Kateřina Konečná	Opposes NATO expansion, advocating for strict national neutrality and anti-militarism.
Geadis Gead	Places national defence sovereignty above both centralized EU defence integration and foreign military reliance.

Relevant UN Treaties, Resolutions, and Reports

Document	Type	When written/adopted]	Full document	Why it is relevant

Charter of the United Nations, Article 51	Treaty / foundational UN legal text	24 October 1945	full text	Recognises the inherent right of individual or collective self-defence. This is the UN Charter basis on which NATO's collective-defence commitment rests.
North Atlantic Treaty	Treaty, not a UN treaty but directly relevant	4 April 1949	full text	Establishes NATO and Article 5 collective defence. It explicitly links NATO's defence commitment to Article 51 of the UN Charter; this is central to Europe's security relationship with the United States.
UN General Assembly Resolution 77/33, "Objective information on military matters, including transparency of military expenditures"	General Assembly resolution	7 December 2022	full text	Encouraged transparency in national military spending. It supports debate on whether European states are spending sufficiently and independently, or relying on U.S. capabilities.
Report of the UN Secretary-General, *Objective information on military matters,*	report	22 July 2024	full report	Reports government-submitted military-expenditure data and follows up on Resolution 77/33. Useful for comparing European defence spending with that of the United States

including transparency of military expenditures				
Pact for the Future, A/RES/79/1	General Assembly resolution	22 September 2024	full text	Requests the Secretary-General to examine the impact of rising military spending on sustainable development; it created the mandate for the 2025 spending report.
The Security We Need: *Rebalancing Military Spending for a Sustainable and Peaceful Future*	Secretary-General report	9 September 2025	full report	Warns that record global military spending may divert resources from development and peace. It is useful for arguing that Europe should balance deterrence with investment in civilian security and development
Overview: *The Security We Need*	Secretary-General report overview	2025	full overview	Shorter version of the Secretary-General's report; useful for delegates who need concise evidence on military-spending trend

Previous Attempts to Solve the Problem

Previous attempts to reduce Europe's military dependence on the United States have focused mainly on increasing European defence spending, coordinating national armed forces, and building EU-level defence structures, but they have often failed because they relied on voluntary commitments, national veto points, and political will that varied sharply among member states. The most important early attempt was NATO's 2014 Wales Summit Defence

Investment Pledge, adopted in Newport, Wales, by all NATO heads of state and government in response to Russia's annexation of Crimea and instability in the Middle East; it committed allies to reverse declining defence budgets, aim to spend 2 percent of GDP on defence by 2024, and devote 20 percent of defence spending to major equipment, research, and development. Although the pledge successfully drew attention to Europe's underinvestment and encouraged some states to raise budgets, it was not legally binding and did not require states to develop the specific European capabilities—such as strategic transport, intelligence, air defence, or ammunition production—that would reduce reliance on U.S. forces; consequently, many members continued to fall short or spent money in ways that did not close NATO-wide capability gaps. A more EU-centred attempt came through the European Parliament's resolution of 16 March 2017 on the common security and defence policy, which called on member states to establish and join Permanent Structured Cooperation (PESCO) in order to improve military capabilities, interoperability, training, infrastructure, and defence-material development. PESCO was formally launched by the European Council in December 2017 and was intended to make European defence spending more efficient while moving toward a strategically autonomous European Defence Union; the European Parliament supported it as a key building block for a common cyber-defence policy and stronger EU military structures. Its weakness, however, was that PESCO remained intergovernmental: participation and implementation depended on individual member states, while defence budgets, procurement choices, and military deployments remained national competences. As a result, it produced many projects and political declarations but did not create a unified European army, common procurement system, or independent command structure capable of replacing critical U.S. assets. The United Nations has also addressed the broader issue through transparency and spending measures, including General Assembly Resolution 77/33 of 7 December 2022 on objective information and transparency of military expenditures, which encouraged states to report military spending more consistently; however, because it focused on transparency rather than capability-building or alliance burden-sharing, it could not directly reduce Europe's operational dependence on the United States. More recently, the UN Secretary-General's 2025 report *The Security We Need: Rebalancing Military Spending for a Sustainable and Peaceful Future*, requested through the 2024 Pact for the Future, warned that record military expenditure could divert resources from sustainable development and peace; it is relevant because it shows that simply increasing budgets is not enough unless spending is directed toward effective, coordinated, and sustainable security capabilities. Overall, these attempts failed not because the need for

reform was ignored, but because they relied too heavily on voluntary targets, fragmented national decision-making, and short-term political commitments rather than binding capability goals, pooled procurement, shared funding, and enforceable timelines. Future action should therefore combine NATO burden-sharing with concrete EU defence-industrial investment, common procurement of critical capabilities, stronger intelligence and logistics cooperation, and transparent reporting, so that Europe can contribute more equally to collective defence while retaining the U.S. security guarantee.

Date	Action / Event	Body or actors involved	What it did	Why it matters / why it fell short
24 October 1945	**UN Charter adopted**, including Article 51	United Nations	Recognised the right of states to individual and collective self-defence.	Became the legal foundation for NATO's collective-defence system, including Europe's security relationship with the United States.
4 April 1949	**North Atlantic Treaty signed**	United States, Canada, and European states	Created NATO and established Article 5 collective defence.	Made European security dependent partly on U.S. military power and leadership; it did not create an equally capable European

				defence structure.
3 November 1950	**UN General Assembly Resolution 377, "Uniting for Peace"**	UN General Assembly	Allowed the General Assembly to act when the Security Council is deadlocked by a veto.	Offered an alternative route for collective security, but it cannot replace NATO's military capabilities or U.S. logistical support.
5 September 2014	**NATO Wales Summit Defence Investment Pledge**	NATO Allies pledged to heads of reverse defence cuts, state and aim to spend 2 percent governmenof GDP on defence by t, meeting 2024, and devote 20 in percent of spending to Newport, major equipment and Wales research.		Increased attention to European underinvestment, but the voluntary pledge was not legally binding and did require Europe to develop independent capabilities, so reliance on U.S. assets remained.
16 March 2017	**European Parliament resolution on the common security and**	European Parliament	Called for deeper EU defence cooperation, strategic autonomy, and the creation of PESCO.	Recognised the need for Europe to act more independently, but it was a political

	defence policy			resolution rather than a binding defence programme.
22 June 2017	**European Council decided to launch PESCO**	European Council and participating EU member states	Approved Permanent Structured Cooperation to deepen defence integration among willing EU states.	Created a framework for cooperation, but participation remained voluntary and implementation depended on national governments.
December 2017	**PESCO formally launched**	European Union and participating member states	Established projects to improve military capabilities, interoperability, training, infrastructure, and defence-industry cooperation.	Aimed to move toward a strategically autonomous European Defence Union, but it did not create a common army, unified command, or shared procurement system.

7 December 2022	**UN General Assembly Resolution 77/33**	UN General Assembly	Encouraged transparency in military matters and military-expenditure reporting.	Improved visibility of defence spending, but it did not address capability gaps or alliance burden-sharing directly.
22 July 2024	**UN Secretary-General report on military-expenditure transparency**	UN Secretary-General	Reported on state military-expenditure data following Resolution 77/33.	Provided evidence for comparing European and U.S. defence spending, but had no enforcement mechanism.
22 September 2024	**UN Pact for the Future adopted**	UN General Assembly	Asked the Secretary-General to examine the effects of rising military spending on sustainable development.	Shifted attention to whether higher defence budgets are being used effectively, rather than simply increasing spending.

9 September 2025	***The Security We Need: Rebalancing Military Spending for a Sustainable and Peaceful Future****	UN Secretary-General	Warned that record military spending can undermine development and peace, and urged more balanced security investment.	Relevant because it suggests Europe should build capabilities strategically rather than relying only on bigger budgets or U.S. support.

Bibliography